

Chapter 3 — Ruling the Countryside

The one-line point: Once the Company held the revenue, it had to decide **who pays, how much, and forever or not**. Three answers — **Permanent Settlement, Mahalwari, Ryotwari** — all failed the peasant. Then it forced him to grow **indigo**, and he revolted.

← Ch.2 | Index | Next: Ch.4 →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Modern India
Sub-discipline	Colonial agrarian & economic history
Period	1765 – 1917
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ <i>History of India</i> → the three land revenue settlements are asked repeatedly
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ Land revenue systems and their impact; commercialisation of agriculture ; peasant movements
Also feeds	Economy ★ ★ ★ (deindustrialisation, commercial crops, rural indebtedness), Geography (crop regions), Modern India Ch.8 (Champaran, Gandhi's first satyagraha)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ ★ — the three settlements are near-guaranteed Prelims content
Overlaps with	Class 12 Theme 9 (<i>Colonialism and the Countryside</i> — the advanced version), Ch.2 (the Diwani), Ch.8 (Champaran)

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **State the date of the Diwani** and explain what being **Diwan** obliged the Company to do. ★
- ☐ **Explain the Bengal crisis** and the **famine of 1770**. ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the Permanent Settlement** — year, Governor-General, terms, intent. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain why it failed** — for the Company, the zamindar **and** the cultivator. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the Mahalwari system** — year, author, region, unit, who collected. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the Ryotwari system** — who devised it, region, rationale. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Compare all three** in a single table. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **List** the commercial crops and their regions. ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain why Europe wanted Indian indigo** — the **woad** story and the 1780s supply collapse. ★ ★
- ☐ **Distinguish *nij* from *ryoti*** cultivation, with the problems of each. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe the indigo production process** — the three vats.
- ☐ **Narrate the Blue Rebellion of 1859** — causes, course, and the **Indigo Commission**. ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Connect** the collapse in Bengal to **Champaran 1917**. ★ ★

Start Here: 12 August 1765

On **12 August 1765**, the Mughal emperor appointed the East India Company as the **Diwan of Bengal**.

★ **A detail worth noticing** — NCERT points it out deliberately:

*"The actual event most probably took place in **Robert Clive's tent**, with a few Englishmen and Indians as witnesses. But in the painting, the event is shown as a **majestic occasion, taking place in a grand setting**. The painter was **commissioned by Clive** to record the memorable events in Clive's life."*

 **A tent redrawn as a throne room.** This is Chapter 1's lesson about images working immediately: the picture is not evidence of the ceremony but evidence of **how Clive wanted it remembered**.

The Company's new problem

As DIWAN, the Company became the CHIEF FINANCIAL ADMINISTRATOR of the territory under its control.

NOW IT HAD TO:

- administer the land
- organise its revenue resources
- in a way that would yield enough revenue to meet its GROWING EXPENSES
- AND, as a trading company, ensure it could BUY the products it needed and SELL what it wanted

BUT ALSO -- and this is the political constraint:

"Being an ALIEN POWER, it needed to PACIFY those who in the past had ruled the countryside and enjoyed authority and prestige. Those who had held local power HAD TO BE CONTROLLED BUT THEY COULD NOT BE ENTIRELY ELIMINATED."

★ **That last constraint explains the Permanent Settlement.** The Company could not simply sweep away the existing rural elite — it needed them as collectors and as a buffer. **Every settlement in this chapter is an attempt to solve "extract maximum revenue without provoking rebellion."**

★ ★ The Bengal Crisis and the Famine of 1770

The Company "had become the Diwan, but it still saw itself primarily as a TRADER. It wanted a large revenue income but was UNWILLING TO SET UP ANY REGULAR SYSTEM of assessment and collection."

THE STRATEGY: increase revenue as much as possible, and buy fine cotton and silk cloth as CHEAPLY as possible

*** Within FIVE YEARS, the value of goods bought by the Company in Bengal DOUBLED. ***

(Before 1765 those goods were paid for with gold and silver from Britain; now Bengal's own revenue financed them -- Ch.2)

|
v

THE CONSEQUENCES, in NCERT's words:

- "ARTISANS WERE DESERTING VILLAGES since they were being FORCED TO SELL THEIR GOODS TO THE COMPANY AT LOW PRICES"
- "PEASANTS were unable to pay the dues demanded from them"
- "ARTISANAL PRODUCTION WAS IN DECLINE, and agricultural cultivation showed SIGNS OF COLLAPSE"

|
v

*** THEN IN 1770, A TERRIBLE FAMINE KILLED TEN MILLION PEOPLE IN BENGAL. ABOUT ONE-THIRD OF THE POPULATION WAS WIPED OUT. ***

★ ★ ★ The Bengal Famine of 1770 is one of the most important facts in Modern Indian history, and the numbers are asked directly: TEN MILLION dead, ONE-THIRD of the population.

🎯 And note the sequence NCERT constructs. The famine follows immediately after a description of maximum extraction with no system of assessment, forced sales at low prices, and peasants unable to pay. The book does not say "the Company caused the famine" — but it places the two paragraphs side by side, and the argument is unmistakable. A drought became a catastrophe because the revenue demand did not fall when the harvest did.

📖 A system running at maximum extraction has **no headroom**. Any shock becomes a total failure because all the slack has already been consumed.

2 ★ ★ ★ The Permanent Settlement, 1793

Fact	Detail
★ ★ Year	1793
★ ★ Governor-General	CHARLES CORNWALLIS
Preceded by	"Two decades of debate on the question"
The reasoning	"If the economy was in ruins, could the Company be certain of its revenue income?" Officials felt investment in land had to be encouraged and agriculture improved

★ ★ ★ The terms

[1] The RAJAS and TALUQDARS were recognised as *** ZAMINDARS ***

[2] They were asked to COLLECT RENT FROM THE PEASANTS and PAY REVENUE TO THE COMPANY

[3] *** THE AMOUNT TO BE PAID WAS FIXED PERMANENTLY -- "it was not to be increased ever in future" ***

★ The intended logic:

This would **ensure a regular flow of revenue** into the Company's coffers **and at the same time encourage the zamindars to invest in improving the land** — since the revenue demand would not be increased, **the zamindar would keep the benefit of any increased production.**

 **The design intent was to create an incentive to invest.** Fix the state's claim permanently, and every extra rupee of output accrues to the improver. **In theory, a rational landlord would now develop his estate.** It is not a stupid idea. It simply did not work.

★ ★ ★ **Why it failed — three failures, three victims**

FAILURE 1 -- FOR THE ZAMINDARS (early years)
"The revenue that had been fixed was SO HIGH that the zamindars found it DIFFICULT TO PAY."
"Anyone who FAILED TO PAY the revenue LOST HIS ZAMINDARI."
*** "NUMEROUS ZAMINDARS WERE SOLD OFF AT AUCTIONS organised by the Company." ***

FAILURE 2 -- FOR THE COMPANY (after c. 1800)
"By the first decade of the nineteenth century... PRICES IN THE MARKET ROSE and CULTIVATION SLOWLY EXPANDED."
-> "an INCREASE IN THE INCOME OF THE ZAMINDARS but
*** NO GAIN FOR THE COMPANY, since it could not increase a revenue demand that had been FIXED PERMANENTLY. ***"

FAILURE 3 -- THE INVESTMENT NEVER CAME
"Even then the zamindars did NOT have an interest in improving the land."
- some had LOST their lands in the early years
- others "now saw the possibility of EARNING WITHOUT THE TROUBLE AND RISK OF INVESTMENT"
*** "As long as the zamindars could GIVE OUT THE LAND TO TENANTS AND GET RENT, they were NOT INTERESTED IN IMPROVING it." ***

★ ★ ★ **This is the answer to "critically examine the Permanent Settlement", and the shape of it is elegant:**

It failed twice, in opposite directions. In the first decade the demand was **too high** and ruined the zamindars. After 1800 it was **too low** and cheated the Company. **The one thing it never did was produce the agricultural investment that justified it.**

 **The incentive was real but the easier path was rent-seeking.** Why take the risk of improving land when you can simply lease it out and collect? **The scheme assumed the landlord would behave like an entrepreneur; he behaved like a rentier.**

★ ★ **And the cultivator — the worst outcome**

*"On the other hand, in the villages, the cultivator found the system **EXTREMELY OPPRESSIVE**. The **rent he paid to the zamindar was HIGH** and **his right on the land was INSECURE**. To pay the rent he had to often **TAKE A LOAN FROM THE MONEYLENDER**, and when he failed to pay the rent, **he was EVICTED from the land he had cultivated for generations.**"*

★ **Note the three-part trap: high rent → debt → eviction.** This is the origin of the **rural indebtedness** that defines the Indian countryside right into the twentieth century, and it is why moneylenders become a target in later peasant movements.

★ **The under-tenants were worse off still.** In 1806 **H. T. Colebrook** described how powerful ryots in Bengal did not cultivate but **leased their land to under-tenants at very high rents**, so that these under-tenants *"depressed by an excessive rent in kind, and by usurious returns for the cattle, seed, and subsistence advanced to them, **can never extricate themselves from debt...** they cannot labour in spirit, while they earn a scanty subsistence **without hope of bettering their situation.**"*

3 ★ ★ ★ The Mahalwari Settlement, 1822

Fact	Detail
★ ★ Who	HOLT MACKENZIE , an Englishman
★ ★ Year in effect	1822
★ ★ Where	The North Western Provinces of the Bengal Presidency — <i>"most of this area is now in Uttar Pradesh"</i>
★ His premise	<i>"He felt that the VILLAGE was an important social institution in north Indian society and needed to be PRESERVED."</i>

★ ★ The method:

Under his directions, COLLECTORS went from VILLAGE TO VILLAGE:

- INSPECTING the land
- MEASURING the fields
- RECORDING the customs and rights of different groups

|

v

The estimated revenue of EACH PLOT within a village was ADDED UP to calculate the revenue that each village (** MAHAL **) had to pay

|

v

*** THIS DEMAND WAS TO BE REVISED PERIODICALLY, NOT PERMANENTLY FIXED. ***

|

v

*** The charge of COLLECTING the revenue and paying it to the Company was given to THE VILLAGE HEADMAN, RATHER THAN THE ZAMINDAR. ***

★ ★ Two deliberate reversals of the Permanent Settlement — and both are exam points:

1. **Periodic revision instead of permanent fixing** → the Company would not be locked out of rising prices again
2. **The village headman instead of the zamindar** → no intermediary landlord class created

★ **MAHAL** = *"in British revenue records, a **revenue estate** which may be a **village or a group of villages.**"* Learn this definition.

4 ★ ★ ★ The Ryotwari (Munro) System

Fact	Detail
★ ★ Who devised it	Tried on a small scale by ★ CAPTAIN ALEXANDER READ, in areas taken over after the wars with Tipu Sultan; ★ subsequently developed by THOMAS MUNRO
★ ★ Where	Gradually extended all over SOUTH INDIA. (Munro was Governor of Madras, 1819–26)
★ ★ The premise	"Read and Munro felt that in the south there were NO TRADITIONAL ZAMINDARS. "
★ ★ ★ The terms	"The settlement had to be made DIRECTLY WITH THE CULTIVATORS (RYOTS) who had tilled the land for generations. Their fields had to be carefully and SEPARATELY SURVEYED before the revenue assessment was made."
★ The ideology	"Munro thought that the British should act as PATERNAL FATHER FIGURES protecting the ryots under their charge."

🎯 **The paternalism line is worth quoting.** It captures the self-image of the colonial administrator perfectly — and it sits very awkwardly beside what actually happened next.

⚠️ ★ ★ ★ "All was not well" — the common failure

*"Within a few years after the new systems were imposed, it was clear that **all was not well** with them. Driven by the desire to increase the income from land, **revenue officials FIXED TOO HIGH A REVENUE DEMAND. Peasants were unable to pay, RYOTS FLED THE COUNTRYSIDE, and VILLAGES BECAME DESERTED in many regions.** Optimistic officials had imagined that the new systems would **transform the peasants into rich enterprising farmers. BUT THIS DID NOT HAPPEN.**"*

★ ★ This is the single most important sentence in the chapter for a Mains answer. All three systems — permanent, periodic, and direct-with-the-cultivator — **failed in the same way and for the same reason: the demand was set too high**, because the purpose was always revenue maximisation, not agricultural improvement. **The institutional design varied; the extractive intent did not.**

★ ★ ★ The Three Settlements — Comparison Table

Memorise this. It is the highest-yield table in the book.

	PERMANENT SETTLEMENT	MAHALWARI	RYOTWARI
★ Year	1793	1822	Early 19th c. (Read → Munro)
★ Associated with	Cornwallis	Holt Mackenzie	Alexander Read, Thomas Munro
★ Where	Bengal (Bengal Presidency)	North Western Provinces (mostly UP)	South India (Madras Presidency)
★★ Revenue paid by	ZAMINDARS (rajas and taluqdars)	The VILLAGE (mahal), through the village headman	The RYOT (cultivator) directly
★★ Demand fixed?	PERMANENTLY — never to be increased	REVISED PERIODICALLY	Periodically revised
Unit of assessment	The zamindari estate	The mahal — a village or group of villages	The individual field, separately surveyed
Rationale	Encourage zamindars to invest	Preserve the village as a social institution	No traditional zamindars in the south; deal with the tiller
⚠ Outcome	Zamindaris auctioned off ; Company locked out of rising prices ; no investment ; cultivators evicted and indebted	Demand still too high	Demand still too high ; ryots fled , villages deserted

🧠 **Memory hook: "Corn-Perm-Bengal • Mack-Mahal-UP • Munro-Ryot-South."** And the paying party: **zamindar / village / cultivator.**

5 ★★ Crops for Europe

*"The British also realised that the countryside could not only yield revenue, it could also **grow the crops that EUROPE REQUIRED.**"*

By the late eighteenth century the Company was expanding **opium** and **indigo**. In the century and a half that followed, the British "**persuaded or forced**" cultivators to produce:

Crop	Region
★ Jute	Bengal
★ Tea	Assam
★ Sugarcane	United Provinces (now Uttar Pradesh)
★ Wheat	Punjab
★ Cotton	Maharashtra and Punjab
★ Rice	Madras

🗨️ **Learn these six pairings — they are a stock matching question.** And note the phrase **"persuaded or forced"**: NCERT is signalling that this was the **commercialisation of agriculture under compulsion**, not a market response.

★ **The consequence worth stating in Mains:** land shifted from **food for the cultivator** to **cash crops for export**, which raised vulnerability to famine and tied the Indian peasant to distant price movements he could not see or influence.

6 ★★ Why Europe Wanted Indian Indigo

A genuinely interesting story of global economics — and NCERT tells it well.

THE COLOUR PROBLEM

INDIGO grows primarily in the TROPICS.

By the 13th century Indian indigo was used by cloth manufacturers in ITALY, FRANCE and BRITAIN.

BUT: "only SMALL AMOUNTS of Indian indigo reached the European market and ITS PRICE WAS VERY HIGH."

So European manufacturers depended on *** WOAD *** -- a plant of the TEMPERATE zones, easily available in Europe, grown in northern Italy, southern France, parts of Germany and Britain.

*** WOAD PRODUCERS, worried by the competition, PRESSURISED THEIR GOVERNMENTS TO BAN THE IMPORT OF INDIGO. ***

BUT CLOTH DYERS PREFERRED INDIGO:

- indigo produced a RICH BLUE colour
- the dye from woad was PALE AND DULL

By the 17th century European cloth producers persuaded their governments to RELAX the ban.

Plantations sprang up: the FRENCH in ST DOMINGUE (Caribbean), the PORTUGUESE in BRAZIL, the ENGLISH in JAMAICA, the SPANISH in VENEZUELA, and across NORTH AMERICA.

★★ The supply collapse of the 1780s — and India's opening

Development	Detail
Demand rose	"Britain began to INDUSTRIALISE , and its cotton production expanded dramatically , creating an enormous new demand for cloth dyes "
★ Supply collapsed	"Between 1783 and 1789 , the production of indigo in the world FELL BY HALF "
★ Why	In St Domingue , the African slaves who worked the plantations rose in rebellion in 1791 , burning the plantations and killing the planters; France abolished slavery in its colonies in 1792 . These events collapsed the Caribbean indigo plantations

★★ The result for India:

"From the last decades of the 18th century, indigo cultivation in BENGAL EXPANDED RAPIDLY and Bengal indigo came to DOMINATE THE WORLD MARKET."

1788 -> only about *** 30 PER CENT *** of the indigo imported into Britain was from India
1810 -> the proportion had gone up to *** 95 PER CENT ***

★★ The 30% → 95% figures are directly asked. And notice the causal chain, which is superb Mains material: **a slave revolt in the Caribbean in 1791 → the collapse of Atlantic indigo → forced indigo cultivation on Bengali peasants**. Colonial economies were a single connected system; a rebellion in Haiti reshaped agriculture in Bengal.

Who became planters: "commercial agents and officials of the Company began investing in indigo production. Over the years *many Company officials left their jobs* to look after their indigo business. Attracted by the prospect of high profits, **numerous Scotsmen and Englishmen came to India and became planters**. Those who had no money could get **loans from the Company and the banks**."

7 ★★ ★ *Nij* vs *Ryoti* — How Indigo Was Cultivated

A guaranteed comparison question.

	★ <i>NIJ</i> CULTIVATION	★ <i>RYOTI</i> CULTIVATION
Whose land	Land the planter directly controlled — bought, or rented from zamindars	★ The ryot's own land
Who works it	Directly employed hired labourers	The ryot and his family
Share of production	★ Less than 25% of indigo land	★ The rest — the great majority

⚠ ★★ ★ Why *nij* could not expand — four obstacles

[1] LAND

Indigo needed FERTILE land -- and fertile land was ALREADY DENSELY POPULATED. Only "small plots scattered over the landscape" could be acquired, but planters needed "LARGE AREAS IN COMPACT BLOCKS". Attempts to lease land around the factory and EVICT the peasants "ALWAYS LED TO CONFLICTS AND TENSION".

[2] LABOUR

"A large plantation required a VAST NUMBER OF HANDS... and labour was needed PRECISELY AT A TIME WHEN PEASANTS WERE USUALLY BUSY WITH THEIR RICE CULTIVATION."

[3] PLOUGHS AND BULLOCKS

*** One BIGHA of indigo required TWO PLOUGHS.
A planter with 1,000 bighas would need 2,000 PLOUGHS. ***
Investment in purchase and maintenance was a big problem.

[4] TIMING AGAIN

Peasants' own ploughs and bullocks were busy on their rice fields "exactly at the time that the indigo planters needed them".

★ The 1 bigha : 2 ploughs ratio (so 1,000 bighas : 2,000 ploughs) is a favourite detail. (A *bigha* was standardised by the British in Bengal to about **one-third of an acre**.)

🎯 Notice that obstacles [2] and [4] are the same conflict: indigo and rice **compete for the same labour, ploughs and bullocks at the same moment in the year**. Indigo could only expand by **taking those resources away from food production** — which is exactly why the peasant resisted.

★★★★ The *ryoti* system — the debt trap

[1] Planters FORCED the ryots to sign a contract, an agreement (*** SATTA ***). At times they pressurised the VILLAGE HEADMEN to sign on behalf of the ryots.

[2] Those who signed got *** CASH ADVANCES at low rates of interest *** to produce indigo.

[3] BUT the loan committed the ryot to cultivating indigo on *** AT LEAST 25 PER CENT of the area under his holding. ***

[4] The planter provided the SEED and the DRILL; the cultivators PREPARED THE SOIL, SOWED THE SEED and LOOKED AFTER THE CROP.

[5] When the crop was delivered after harvest, *** A NEW LOAN WAS GIVEN, AND THE CYCLE STARTED ALL OVER AGAIN. ***

"The price they got for the indigo they produced was VERY LOW and *** THE CYCLE OF LOANS NEVER ENDED. ***"

★★ And two further injuries:

Problem	Detail
Best land taken	"The planters usually insisted that indigo be cultivated on the BEST SOILS , in which peasants preferred to cultivate RICE ."
★★ Soil exhaustion	"*Indigo had DEEP ROOTS and it EXHAUSTED THE SOIL RAPIDLY . After an indigo harvest the land COULD NOT BE SOWN WITH RICE ."*

★★★★ That last line is the crux of the whole grievance, and it is the answer to "why were ryots reluctant to grow indigo?"

It was not merely that indigo paid badly. **Growing indigo destroyed the field's ability to grow food**. The peasant was being paid a low price, in a loan he could never repay, to **permanently damage his own means of subsistence**.

💻 The contract extracted a one-way, irreversible cost from the counterparty while the planter bore none of it — and the loan structure made refusal impossible. **A debt instrument used as a coercion mechanism**.

How indigo was produced — the three vats ★

[1] *** FERMENTING (STEEPER) VAT ***

Leaves stripped from the plant are SOAKED IN WARM WATER for several hours. As they ferment the liquid BOILS AND BUBBLES. Rotten leaves removed; liquid drained into...

[2] *** BEATER VAT ***

The solution is CONTINUOUSLY STIRRED AND BEATEN WITH PADDLES. As it turns GREEN and then BLUE, LIME WATER is added. Indigo separates out in FLAKES; a MUDDY SEDIMENT settles at the bottom; CLEAR LIQUID rises to the surface. The liquid is drained off and the sediment -- the indigo pulp -- transferred to...

[3] *** SETTLING VAT ***

Then PRESSED and DRIED for sale.

★ **The human cost of step 2:** the vat-beaters *"had to remain in **WAIST-DEEP WATER FOR OVER EIGHT HOURS** to beat the indigo solution."* Women usually carried the plant to the vats.

8 ★ ★ ★ The "Blue Rebellion", March 1859

What happened

*"In March 1859, thousands of ryots in Bengal **REFUSED TO GROW INDIGO.**"*

The action
Ryots refused to pay rents to the planters
Attacked indigo factories armed with swords and spears, bows and arrows
★ "WOMEN TURNED UP TO FIGHT with pots, pans and kitchen implements"
Those who worked for the planters were socially boycotted
The gomasthas — agents of planters — who came to collect rent were beaten up
Ryots swore they would no longer take advances nor be bullied by the planters' lathiyals — the lathi-wielding strongmen maintained by the planters

★ ★ ★ Why 1859? — NCERT's own question, and the answer

*"Clearly, the indigo system was intensely oppressive. **But those who are oppressed DO NOT ALWAYS RISE UP IN REBELLION. They do so only at times.**"*

Three enabling conditions:

#	Condition
★ 1. Local elite support	"The indigo ryots felt they had the support of the LOCAL ZAMINDARS AND VILLAGE HEADMEN ." Headmen who had been forced to sign indigo contracts mobilised the peasants and fought pitched battles with the lathiyals. In other places zamindars went around villages urging the ryots to resist — they were unhappy at the increasing power of the planters and angry at being forced to give them land on long leases
★★ 2. Belief that government would back them	"The indigo peasants also imagined that the British government would SUPPORT them ." ★ After the Revolt of 1857, the government was particularly worried about the possibility of another popular rebellion. When news spread of unrest, the Lieutenant Governor toured the region in the winter of 1859, and the ryots read the tour as sympathy
★★ 3. The Ashley Eden notice	At Barasat, the magistrate ★ ASHLEY EDEN issued a notice stating ryots would not be compelled to accept indigo contracts. ★ "Word went around that QUEEN VICTORIA had declared that indigo need not be sown ." Eden was trying to *placate the peasants and control an explosive situation, but his action was read as SUPPORT FOR THE REBELLION "

★★★ This is a beautifully constructed explanation and outstanding Mains material.

Oppression is necessary but not sufficient for revolt. **What changed in 1859 was the perception of ALLIES and of IMPUNITY** — the peasants believed the zamindars were with them and that the state would not crush them. **1857 had made the government cautious, and that caution was read as permission.**

🌀 The rumour that "Queen Victoria had declared indigo need not be sown" is especially telling — a technical magistrate's notice transmuted, as it travelled, into a royal sanction. **Rumour as a mobilising force** is a theme you will meet again in Chapter 5 (the chapatis and the greased cartridges).

📖 And the intellectuals

"As the rebellion spread, intellectuals from CALCUTTA rushed to the indigo districts. They wrote of the misery of the ryots, the tyranny of the planters, and the horrors of the indigo system."

(The most famous product of this was Dinabandhu Mitra's play **Nil Darpan** — not named in the rationalised text, but standard knowledge and worth carrying.)

⚖️ ★★★ The Indigo Commission

Government response	Detail
Force	"The government brought in the MILITARY to protect the planters from assault"
★★ Inquiry	"...and set up the INDIGO COMMISSION to enquire into the system of indigo production"

★★ The Commission's findings:

- [1] It HELD THE PLANTERS GUILTY
- [2] It CRITICISED THEM for the COERCIVE METHODS they used
- [3] It declared that *** INDIGO PRODUCTION WAS NOT PROFITABLE FOR RYOTS ***
- [4] It asked the ryots to FULFIL THEIR EXISTING CONTRACTS but told them they could *** REFUSE TO PRODUCE INDIGO IN FUTURE ***

★ And the peasant's own voice — Hadji Mulla before the Commission, 5 June 1860:

Seton Karr: "Are you now willing to sow indigo; and if not, on what fresh terms would you be willing to do it?" **Hadji Mulla:** "I am not willing to sow, and **I don't know that any fresh terms would satisfy me.**" **Mr Sale:** "Would you not be willing to sow at a rupee a bundle?" **Hadji Mulla:** "No I would not; rather than sow indigo **I will go to another country; I WOULD RATHER BEG THAN SOW INDIGO.**"*

★ ★ **Quote this.** It is a rare instance of a peasant speaking **in his own words, in an official record** — precisely the voice Chapter 1 said the archive normally omits. And his answer refuses the entire premise of the question: **there is no price at which this is acceptable.**

9 ★ ★ After the Rebellion — and Champaran

"After the revolt, INDIGO PRODUCTION COLLAPSED IN BENGAL."

|

v

*** "But the planters now SHIFTED THEIR OPERATION TO BIHAR." ***

|

v

With the discovery of *** SYNTHETIC DYES *** in the late 19th century their business was severely affected, "but yet they managed to EXPAND PRODUCTION".

|

v

"When MAHATMA GANDHI returned from SOUTH AFRICA, a PEASANT FROM BIHAR persuaded him to visit CHAMPARAN and see the plight of the indigo cultivators there."

|

v

*** "Mahatma Gandhi's visit in 1917 marked the beginning of the CHAMPARAN MOVEMENT against the indigo planters." ***

★ ★ ★ **This is one of the most important connections in the entire NCERT History series, and it is easy to miss.**

Gandhi's first satyagraha in India was against the indigo system described in this chapter. The oppression the Bengal ryots revolted against in 1859 **simply relocated to Bihar** and continued for another half-century — until a peasant named **Raj Kumar Shukla** (not named here, but standard) went and fetched Gandhi.

🔗 **Chapter 3 → Chapter 8.** When you write about Champaran in the national movement, **begin here:** it was not a random first campaign, it was the culmination of a **150-year-old struggle over a single crop.**

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Diwani ★★	12 August 1765
Bengal famine ★★★	1770; ten million dead; one-third of the population
Permanent Settlement ★★★	1793, Cornwallis, Bengal; rajas and taluqdars recognised as zamindars ; demand fixed forever
Its failures ★★★	Zamindaris auctioned ; Company gained nothing when prices rose; no investment ; cultivators evicted and indebted
Colebrook, 1806 ★	Described the under-tenants trapped in debt
Mahalwari ★★★	1822, Holt Mackenzie, North Western Provinces (UP); unit = mahal ; village headman collects; periodically revised
Mahal ★	A revenue estate — a village or group of villages
Ryotwari ★★★	Alexander Read → Thomas Munro; South India; settlement directly with the ryot ; fields separately surveyed
Munro	Governor of Madras, 1819–26; the paternal father figure ideology
Common failure ★★	Demand too high ; ryots fled ; villages deserted
Commercial crops ★★	Jute–Bengal, Tea–Assam, Sugarcane–UP, Wheat–Punjab, Cotton–Maharashtra & Punjab, Rice–Madras
Woad ★★	The European temperate rival to indigo; pale and dull ; woad growers lobbied to ban indigo
Indigo share ★★	30% of British imports in 1788 → 95% by 1810
World production ★	Fell by half between 1783 and 1789
St Domingue ★	Slave revolt 1791; France abolished slavery in its colonies 1792
Nij vs Ryoti ★★★	Planter's own land with hired labour (under 25%) vs the ryot's own land under contract
Satta ★	The indigo contract
The 25% rule ★★	The loan committed the ryot to indigo on at least 25% of his holding
Bigha : ploughs ★	1 bigha needed 2 ploughs ; 1,000 bighas → 2,000 ploughs . A bigha ≈ one-third of an acre
Soil exhaustion ★★	Indigo's deep roots ; rice could not be sown after an indigo harvest
Blue Rebellion ★★★	March 1859; women fought with pots and pans ; gomasthas beaten; lathiyals resisted
Ashley Eden ★★	Magistrate at Barasat ; his notice was read as Queen Victoria's order
Indigo Commission ★★★	Held planters guilty ; indigo not profitable for ryots ; ryots could refuse in future
Champaran ★★	Planters shifted to Bihar ; Gandhi's visit in 1917
Synthetic dyes ★	Late nineteenth century

Traps:

- "The Permanent Settlement was introduced by Warren Hastings" → **FALSE**. Cornwallis, 1793
- "Under Mahalwari the zamindar collected the revenue" → **FALSE**. The **village headman**
- "Ryotwari was introduced in Bengal" → **FALSE**. South India; Bengal had the Permanent Settlement
- "The Permanent Settlement benefited the Company as prices rose" → **FALSE**. It could not raise a permanently fixed demand

- "Most indigo was grown on planters' own land" → **FALSE**. *Nij* was **under 25%**; most was **ryoti**
- "The Indigo Commission sided with the planters" → **FALSE**. It held them **guilty**
- "Champaran was against the zamindars" → **FALSE**. Against the **indigo planters**

Mains

- ★★ ★ "Critically examine the Permanent Settlement of 1793." — the **double failure** (too high, then too low) plus the **absence of investment**
- ★★ ★ "Compare the three land revenue systems and assess their impact on the Indian peasantry."
- ★★ ★ "The commercialisation of agriculture under colonial rule was coerced, not market-driven." Discuss — indigo, the *satta*, the 25% rule, soil exhaustion
- ★★ "Oppression alone does not produce rebellion." Explain with reference to the Blue Rebellion of 1859
- ★★ **Economy**: rural indebtedness — high rent → moneylender → eviction — as the structural legacy of colonial land settlements
- ★ **Global history**: how a slave revolt in the Caribbean reshaped Bengal's agriculture

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Diwan	Chief financial administrator; holder of revenue rights
Zamindar	Landholder recognised as revenue payer under the Permanent Settlement
Taluqdar	Holder of a taluq; a large landholder
Mahal	A revenue estate — a village or group of villages
Ryot	A cultivator
Nij	Indigo cultivation on the planter's own land
Ryoti	Indigo cultivation on the ryot's land under contract
Satta	The contract/agreement to grow indigo
Gomastha	An agent of the planter
Lathiyal	A lathi-wielding strongman employed by planters
Bigha	Unit of land, standardised in Bengal to about one-third of an acre
Plantation	A large farm operated by a planter using forms of forced labour
Vat	A fermenting or storage vessel
Haat	A weekly village market
Woad	A temperate plant yielding a pale blue dye

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **12 August 1765** — the Company became **Diwan**, and therefore had to administer land and revenue, while being an **alien power that could control but not eliminate the old rural elite**.
2. It maximised revenue with **no proper system of assessment**, forced artisans to sell cheap, and within five years **doubled** its purchases. Then came the **famine of 1770 — ten million dead, one-third of Bengal**.

3. ★ **Permanent Settlement, 1793, Cornwallis:** rajas and taluqdars became **zamindars**, collected rent, paid a **permanently fixed** revenue — meant to encourage **investment**.
4. ★ **It failed three ways:** the demand was **too high** at first (zamindaris **auctioned off**); after 1800 prices rose and the Company **could not raise a fixed demand**; and **zamindars never invested**, preferring rent without risk. **The cultivator paid high rent, borrowed, and was evicted.**
5. ★ **Mahalwari, 1822, Holt Mackenzie, North Western Provinces:** the **village (mahal)** was the unit, the **village headman** collected, and the demand was **periodically revised** — both deliberate reversals of 1793.
6. ★ **Ryotwari, Read then Munro, South India: no traditional zamindars** there, so settle **directly with the ryot**, with fields **separately surveyed**; Munro cast the British as **paternal father figures**.
7. ⚠ **All three failed the same way** — officials **fixed too high a demand**, **ryots fled**, and villages were **deserted**. The peasants never became "rich enterprising farmers".
8. **Crops for Europe:** jute (Bengal), tea (Assam), sugarcane (UP), wheat (Punjab), cotton (Maharashtra and Punjab), rice (Madras) — grown because cultivators were **"persuaded or forced"**.
9. **Indigo:** Europe had only **woad**, which was **pale and dull**; woad growers had lobbied to **ban** indigo. Industrialising Britain's demand soared just as world production **halved (1783–89)** after the **St Domingue slave revolt of 1791**. India's share of British indigo imports went from **30% (1788) to 95% (1810)**.
10. ★ **Nij** (planter's own land, hired labour) stayed **under 25%** because land, labour, ploughs and bullocks all clashed with the **rice** cycle. **Ryoti** dominated: a **satta**, a **cash advance**, a commitment to plant indigo on **25% of the holding**, a **low price**, and a **new loan every year**.
11. ★ ★ **Indigo took the best soil and, with its deep roots, exhausted it — after an indigo harvest the land could not grow rice.**
12. ★ **March 1859 — the Blue Rebellion.** Ryots refused to sow, attacked factories, beat the **gomasthas**; **women fought with pots and pans**. They rose because they believed **zamindars and headmen backed them** and that **the government, nervous after 1857, would not crush them** — a belief confirmed in their eyes by **Ashley Eden's notice at Barasat**, rumoured to be **Queen Victoria's order**.
13. ★ **The Indigo Commission held the planters guilty**, declared indigo **unprofitable for ryots**, and allowed refusal in future. **Hadji Mulla: "I would rather beg than sow indigo."**
14. ★ ★ **Production collapsed in Bengal — and moved to Bihar.** ★ **Gandhi's visit in 1917 began the Champaran movement**, the first satyagraha in India.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Match the following: (a) ryot (b) mahal (c) nij (d) ryoti → (a) peasant (b) village/revenue estate (c) cultivation on the planter's own land (d) cultivation on the ryot's land.
2. Fill in the blanks: (a) Growers of ____ in Europe saw indigo as competition. (b) The international demand for indigo was affected by the discovery of _____. (c) The Champaran movement was against _____. → (a) woad (b) synthetic dyes (c) the indigo planters.
3. Consider the following statements about the Permanent Settlement:
 1. It was introduced in 1793 under Cornwallis.
 2. The revenue demand was fixed permanently.
 3. It succeeded in inducing zamindars to invest in improving the land. → 1 and 2 only. Zamindars preferred rent without the trouble and risk of investment.

4. The Mahalwari settlement differed from the Permanent Settlement in that — → *The demand was revised periodically, and the village headman rather than the zamindar collected it.*
5. Under the ryoti system, a ryot who accepted an advance was committed to growing indigo on — → *At least 25 per cent of the area under his holding.*
6. The Indigo Commission concluded that — → *The planters were guilty, indigo production was not profitable for ryots, and ryots could refuse to grow it in future.*

Mains style

7. *"The Permanent Settlement failed the Company, the zamindar and the cultivator alike."* Critically examine. **(250 words)**
8. Compare the Permanent, Mahalwari and Ryotwari settlements and assess their impact on the peasantry. **(250 words)**
9. *"Colonial commercialisation of agriculture was coerced rather than market-driven."* Discuss with reference to indigo. **(250 words)**
10. *"Oppression alone does not produce rebellion."* Explain the timing of the Blue Rebellion of 1859. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Give year, Governor-General, region and payer for each of the three settlements.
- State three distinct ways the Permanent Settlement failed.
- Why could *nij* cultivation not expand? Give four reasons.
- Why did indigo ruin a peasant's field for rice?
- Give the three conditions that made 1859 the moment of revolt.
- Trace the line from the 1859 rebellion to Champaran 1917.